

Game Design Document (GDD): *Dream Manor: Echoing Fields*

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Overview

Dream Manor: Echoing Fields is a 2D building simulation game designed to be a mobile application encouraging personal growth and creativity through gamified goal-setting and playful interaction. Players take on the role of a manor owner and collaborate with whimsical elf characters to construct a thriving, magical town. By aligning real-life personal development objectives with in-game tasks, *Dream Manor* motivates players to achieve their goals while fostering a sense of accomplishment, creativity, and emotional connection.

This document outlines the game's core mechanics, psychological design principles, tools, characters, and progression system. Key psychological concepts, such as Flow, Immersion, and risk-taking in Magic Circle, are employed to enhance engagement and user satisfaction.

Core Gameplay and Modes: *Dream Manor* operates across three distinct gameplay modes, each designed to cater to different player needs and preferences:

Development Mode

Players use blocks (Aura Stones) and tubes (Spirit Vines) earned through goal completion to build and expand their manor. This Mode focuses on real-life personal development and ensures that all construction reflects tangible progress in the player's goals. The player's manor is a singular, persistent location, symbolizing their achievements. As players purchase construction materials and build up their manor, it visualizes the personal development process.

Plot Mode

In this creative Mode, players can work on unlimited projects using any blocks or tubes from their inventory. The background of this Mode is the players or the Manor Lord's playground to plan their dream manor. Unlike Development Mode, Plot Mode removes resource restrictions, promoting free-form

creativity without constraints as a level variation of the game's difficulty. Therefore, this Mode enables artistic exploration, such as creating pixel art or abstract constructions.

Once players complete the tutorials, they can freely switch between guided goal-setting (Develop Mode) to complete personal development tasks and earn exclusive Mind Imprints, Mana Sparks, and unstructured building (Plot Mode) to be creative. This Mode balances accountability with autonomy, allowing players to experiment while staying connected to their objectives.

Visit Friends Mode

Players can connect with people by searching their Manor ID under this menu, and they can view their friends' constructions in both Development Mode and Plot Mode if the friends set the constructions visible in Settings. On the one hand, because their friends' Mind Imprint collections, appearing NPCs, and numbers of construction materials owned in the Development Mode showcases the friend's commitment to the game and their personal development goal, it enhances player stickiness and reinforces the encouraged behavior of taking actions in the personal development of this game. On the other hand, by visiting friends' Plot mode, players can compete their construction aesthetics without limitation.

Settings

To complement the three modes above, this game's settings include visibility of the player's projects in Plot Mode or constructions in Development Mode, personal goal adjustments, and Manor ID setup.

Psychological Design Principles: The game incorporates psychological theories to create an engaging and satisfying experience.

Flow and Immersion

Players experience Immersion through a constant setting of peace and a magical manor they own with loyal elves, and the elves' personalities play a significant role in maintaining the player's Immersion. For example, Axel, the Carpenter Elf, has playful humor and removes his jacket while working, revealing unexpected muscles that spark a sense of surprise and delight in players. These moments



create a lighthearted, memorable interaction that enhances player engagement.

Similarly, the Guide Elf, Elara's warm guidance ensures players feel supported as they move through their tasks. For instance, she welcomes players with phrases like, "Welcome, my Manor Lord! Your estate is a blank slate—let's get building!" Her supportive presence sets a calming tone, encouraging players to ease into the game's mechanics. These elements keep the experience lighthearted and enjoyable, preventing task completion from becoming a chore.



Elara Kindly Helps Players Adjust Goal Settings

Furthermore, visiting elves such as Mob could appear anywhere if players spend time building in Development Mode and spend Mana Spark to purchase elves' skins. The visiting elves would bring players unique short stories, which deepen the emotional connection.

Players experience Flow by engaging in balanced challenges where tasks are easy and manageable. The process begins with a critical interaction: setting the first goal, such as learning a new skill or completing daily tasks. These objectives translate into in-game milestones, where achieving a goal rewards players with Mana Sparks and exclusive Mind Imprints. For example, an aspiring filmmaker might break their goal into manageable tasks like storyboarding or editing practice, each contributing to their manor's growth.

Next, when the Guide Elf, Elara, asks, "Let's take a look at your first goal," she initiates a structured yet flexible workflow. Depending on the nature of the player's goal, the system either suggests a detailed implementation plan or adapts to the player's custom input. If the goal is measurable and standard, which will be built into the game's system—such as scoring above 1500 on the SAT—Elara confidently replies, "I've got experience with this!" It then breaks the goal into manageable tasks, presenting a timeline like:

- From [start date] to [end date], study 30 TOEFL core vocabulary words daily.
- From [subsequent date] to [end date], study 30 SAT core vocabulary words daily.

Then, the system compiles these into a daily to-do list, with Elara cheerfully adding, "Here's the plan—please take a look!"

Besides, the game encourages adjustment and personalization. Once the plan is presented, players can approve or modify it. If they feel the timeline is too rigid or unrealistic, they can adjust the daily task

count or specify different actions entirely, even deviating from the suggested format. For instance, a player may decide to study for the SAT by taking timed practice tests instead of focusing on vocabulary drills.

The game system offers gentle feedback to ensure goals remain achievable. If the player shortens the timeline too much, Elara might say, "Wow, that's ambitious—you might finish early!" Conversely, if the goal becomes overly demanding, she might caution, "Hmm, this might be hard to complete on time. Let me adjust the end date for you." These subtle nudges, accompanied by visual cues like blinking highlights, encourage players to set realistic and achievable goals without feeling constrained or judged.

Moreover, the game rewards progress, which reinforces Flow. To elaborate, when a goal plan is finalized, players receive a Mind Imprint as a unique decorative badge symbolizing their commitment—and Elara guides them to meet the Carpenter Elf, Axel, to begin construction. At this stage, the Flow deepens as the player is introduced to the concept of task execution. Elara directs the player to the first task on their to-do list, encouraging them to complete it and return for feedback. When the task is marked as complete, the interaction becomes dynamic:

- If the task is completed too quickly, Elara humorously quips, "Wow, you're fast—are you sure you really did it?" gently reminding players to stay genuine in their efforts.
- If the timing is just right, she beams with pride, saying, "Great job! You're doing wonderfully!" reinforcing the player's sense of accomplishment.
- If the task takes longer than expected, Elara asks with concern, "Are you feeling tired? Take a break, then dive back in when you're ready!" This empathetic response acknowledges the player's effort while motivating them to persist.

By creating a responsive and judgment-free environment, the game ensures players remain engaged without feeling rushed or pressured, striking the perfect balance for sustained Flow.

Risk-Taking in a Safe Environment - Magic Circle

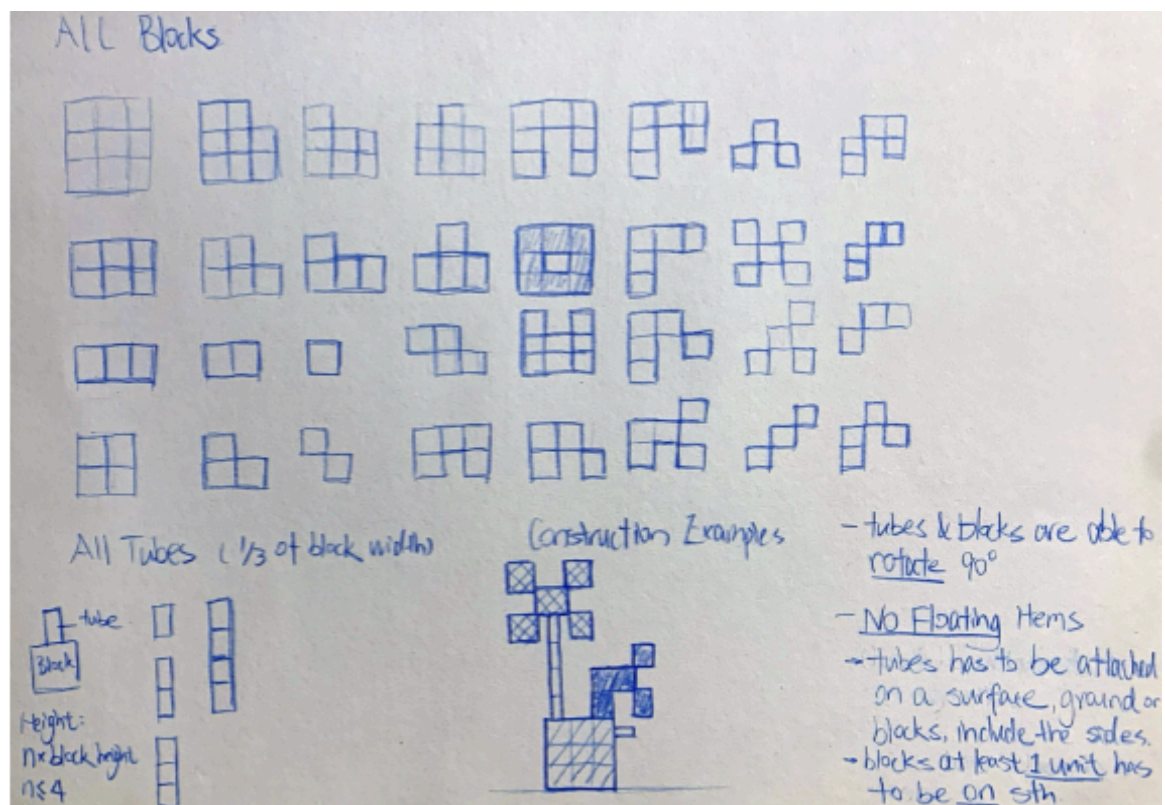
The game encourages players to experiment with goal-setting and creative building without fear of failure. For example, players can adjust goal timelines or redesign structures at no cost, cultivating a Magic Circle. The lighthearted interactions with elves, such as Axel's enthusiastic praise for Liora's profession in fashion and kindly reassure players that mistakes are part of the process.

Personalization and Emotional Connection

The primaries of this game are the Plot Mode and Free-Build Mode, which allow players to step back from goal-driven tasks and explore their artistic side. Whether constructing abstract sculptures or replicating famous landmarks, these modes celebrate creativity and self-expression. Tools like Magic Elixirs (paints in colors like Lavender and Jasmine) and Mind Imprints (customizable badge designs) allow players to personalize their constructions. This customization empowers players to create a unique environment reflecting their personality and achievements, strengthening emotional connections to their manor.

Game Tools and Characters Catalog

Tools



Block and Tube Construction System

- **Aura Stones and Spirit Vines:** Modular building elements used to create structures and landscapes. The largest Aura Stone is a 3x3 cube size; variants remove cubes from this basic 3x3 cube size. Cubic Aura Stones are Kihon. For example, a 2x2 is a medium Kihon. Others are Hade. The Spirit Vines is $\frac{1}{3}$ of the width of the Aura Stones, varying from 1 cube height to 4 cube height. These

grid-based systems offer flexibility and creativity, which enable players to design intricate patterns or functional buildings. Players rotate the materials by tapping and dragging them to place them on the landscape, which can be zoomed in and out through double-finger operation. Players can place construction materials anywhere on their landscape in Plot Mode. However, to build in Development Mode, all Aura Stones must be grounded on a surface, not including the sides, and all Spirit Vines have to be attached on a surface, including the sides.

- **Mana Sparks:** The game's currency, earned by completing tasks. Players use Mana Sparks to purchase building materials and decorative items. The Aura Stones in the Kihon category are lower in price; the larger the cubic size of the Aura Stones is, the higher the price is.
- **Magic Elixirs:** Paints in various plant-inspired colors, such as Rosemary (dark green) and Hibiscus (red), and Cinnamon Magic Elixir for brown as default. Lavender (purple), Sunflower (yellow), Jasmine (light cream), Mint (light green), Sage (teal). This setting is consistent with the game's background and adds a whimsical layer of customization. Each color brings a unique aesthetic, allowing players to create vibrant, expressive designs. One Magic Elixir can only paint one construction material but is reusable. For example, when players paint the material in another color from default, the corresponding Magic Elixirs will be occupied, but players get a Cinnamon Magic Elixir in storage.
- **Mind Imprints:** Badges awarded for achieving milestones. These serve as visual reminders of progress. Some are purchasable Mana Sparks at Axel's workshop, while some are exclusive to specific goals, which will motivate players to stay on track to complete their goals. They can be embossed on the player's owned Aura Stones, and the density of the



Mind Imprints Density Adjustments

pattern can be adjusted. They are reusable and removable from the Aura Stones at any time in Axel's workshop.

Character



Characters

- Elara, the Guide Elf: A nurturing figure who helps players set realistic goals and provides encouragement. Her calm demeanor ensures players feel supported throughout their journey.
- Axel, the Carpenter Elf: A direct yet humorous character who oversees construction. His design and leadership qualities inject energy into the building process.
- Liora, the Clothing Elf: A stylish, tropical spirit assisting elf customization. Her playful attitude and vibrant color palette make the game lively.
- Visitor Elves: Unique, collectible characters with backstories. For instance, Mob, the first visitor elf, exudes a laid-back charm, occasionally offering rent payments or small gifts.

Visual Aesthetics and Emotional Impact

Aesthetic Design (A in MDA Framework) And Overall Effect: The visual and auditory design cultivates a peaceful, engaging world where players feel motivated to progress.

The game features whimsical line art with soft, earthy tones like #c0b7b1 and #eed987, creating a cozy yet lively atmosphere. The muted background contrasts with vibrant characters and structures, ensuring visual clarity and focus. The game's background music is peaceful and fantasy-like, enhancing focus and Immersion.



Emotional Resonance

The elves' playful dialogue and charming personalities encourage players to form emotional bonds with the characters. For example, Liora's fashionable flair and encouraging tone make players eager to revisit her for outfit advice. These connections deepen Immersion and enhance the overall gaming experience.

Market Analysis

Problem Statement

Modern players often need help to focus on their primary personal development goals due to the allure of other intriguing but less urgent activities. This game addresses this issue by gamifying goal management, helping players balance competing priorities in a delightful, engaging manner.

Target Audience

From students to young professionals, aspiring achievers seek a structured yet playful way to manage personal growth and time.

Conclusion

Dream Manor: Echoing Fields blends gamification with psychological principles to create a uniquely engaging experience. By aligning personal growth with interactive gameplay, the game empowers players to achieve their goals while nurturing creativity and emotional connection. Whether building a personal manor in Development Mode or exploring artistic possibilities in Plot Mode, *Dream Manor* offers a safe, supportive environment for experimentation and growth. The game invites players into a magical world where their aspirations come to life through its charming characters, customizable tools, and balanced challenges.